

WEEK 22

SUNDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *2 Kings 14: 1 – 27*

The kingdoms of Amaziah in Judah and Jeroboam II in Israel.

A reading from the second book of Kings.

In the second year of Jo'ash the son of Jo'ahaz, king of Israel, Amazi'ah the son of Jo'ash, king of Judah, began to reign. He was twenty-five years old when he began to reign, and he reigned twenty-nine years in Jerusalem. His mother's name was Jeho-ad'din of Jerusalem. And he did what was right in the eyes of the LORD, yet not like David his father; he did in all things as Jo'ash his father had done. But the high places were not removed; the people still sacrificed and burned incense on the high places.

And as soon as the royal power was firmly in his hand he killed his servants who had slain the king his father. But he did not put to death the children of the murderers; according to what is written in the book of the law of Moses, where the LORD commanded, "The fathers shall not be put to death for the children, or the children be put to death for the fathers; but every man shall die for his own sin."

He killed ten thousand E'domites in the Valley of Salt and took Sela by storm, and called it Jok'the-el, which is its name to this day.

Then Amazi'ah sent messengers to Jeho'ash the son of Jeho'ahaz, son of Jehu, king of Israel, saying, "Come, let us look one another in the face."

And Jeho'ash king of Israel sent word to Amazi'ah king of Judah, "A thistle on Lebanon sent to a cedar on Lebanon, saying, 'Give your daughter to my son for a wife'; and a wild beast of Lebanon passed by and trampled down the thistle.

You have indeed smitten Edom, and your heart has lifted you up. Be content with your glory, and stay at home; for why should you provoke trouble so that you fall, you and Judah with you?"

But Amazi'ah would not listen. So Jeho'ash king of Israel went up, and he and Amazi'ah king of Judah faced one another in battle at Beth-she'mesh, which belongs to Judah. And Judah was defeated by Israel, and every man fled to his home. And Jeho'ash king of Israel captured Amazi'ah

king of Judah, the son of Jeho'ash, son of Ahazi'ah, at Beth-she'mesh, and came to Jerusalem, and broke down the wall of Jerusalem for four hundred cubits, from the E'phraim Gate to the Corner Gate. And he seized all the gold and silver, and all the vessels that were found in the house of the LORD and in the treasuries of the king's house, also hostages, and he returned to Sama'ria.

Now the rest of the acts of Jeho'ash which he did, and his might, and how he fought with Amazi'ah king of Judah, are they not written in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Israel?

And Jeho'ash slept with his fathers, and was buried in Sama'ria with the kings of Israel; and Jerobo'am his son reigned in his stead.

Amazi'ah the son of Jo'ash, king of Judah, lived fifteen years after the death of Jeho'ash son of Jeho'ahaz, king of Israel.

Now the rest of the deeds of Amazi'ah, are they not written in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Judah? And they made a conspiracy against him in Jerusalem, and he fled to Lachish. But they sent after him to Lachish, and slew him there. And they brought him upon horses; and he was buried in Jerusalem with his fathers in the city of David. And all the people of Judah took Azari'ah, who was sixteen years old, and made him king instead of his father Amazi'ah. He built Elath and restored it to Judah, after the king slept with his fathers.

In the fifteenth year of Amazi'ah the son of Jo'ash, king of Judah, Jerobo'am the son of Jo'ash, king of Israel, began to reign in Sama'ria, and he reigned forty-one years. And he did what was evil in the sight of the LORD; he did not depart from all the sins of Jerobo'am the son of Nebat, which he made Israel to sin.

He restored the border of Israel from the entrance of Hamath as far as the Sea of the Arabah, according to the word of the LORD, the God of Israel, which he spoke by his servant Jonah the son of Amit'tai, the prophet, who was from Gath-he'pher. For the LORD saw that the affliction of Israel was very bitter, for there was none left, bond or free, and there was none to help Israel. But the LORD had not said that he would blot out the name of Israel from under heaven, so he saved them by the hand of Jerobo'am the son of Jo'ash.

Responsorial. *Am. 9: 7, 8; 5: 14*

R: Was it not I who brought you out of the land of Egypt? Word of the Lord. Behold the eyes of the Lord are turned towards the sinful kingdom. * Yet I am not going to destroy the house of Jacob completely.

V: Seek good and not evil, so that you may live, and that the Lord God may really be with you.

R: Yet I am not going to destroy the house of Jacob completely.

Second Reading. Nm. 6 – 7

Pure and immaculate for the day of the Lord.

A reading from the “Discourses on baptism” of St. Pacian, bishop.

“Even as we have borne the likeness of the earthly, let us bear also the likeness of the heavenly....The first man was of the earth, earthly; the second man is from heaven, heavenly.” If we act in this manner, dearly beloved brethren, we shall die no more. For even if we are dissolved in this bodily life, we will live in Christ, as he himself has assured us: “He who believes in me, even if he die, shall live.” In a word, we are assured, on God’s word, that Abraham, Isaac, Jacob and all the saints of God live. For God says concerning them: “Now he is not the God of the dead, but of the living, for all live by him.” And the apostle says of himself: “For me to live is Christ and to die is gain. I desire to depart and to be with Christ.” And elsewhere he says: “While we are in the body we are exiled from the Lord for we walk by faith and not by sight.

This, dearly beloved, is our faith: “If with this life only in view we have had hope in Christ, we are of all men the most to be pitied.” Earthly life, as you yourselves see, for beasts, domestic animals, and the birds of the air is of the same span or longer than ours. What is special to man is what Christ has given him through his Spirit – that is, life everlasting, on condition, however, that we sin no more. For just as death is a penalty of sin and virtue the way to avoid it, so life is conserved by virtue and lost by vice. The wages of sin is death, but the gift of God is life everlasting in Christ Jesus our Lord.

It is he who has redeemed us, forgiving us all our sins, cancelling the decree against us, which was hostile to us. Indeed, he has taken it completely away, nailing it to the cross. Disarming the principalities and powers, he displayed them openly, leading them away in his triumphal procession. He released the captives and broke our bonds, as David had

said: “The Lord sets captives free; the Lord gives sight to the blind; the Lord raises up those that were bowed down.” And in another place he says: “You have loosened my bonds. I will offer to you the offering of praise.”

Freed from our chains, when we rally round the standard of the Lord through the sacrament of baptism, we are delivered by the blood and the name of Christ.

Therefore, my dearly beloved brethren, we are washed but once; we are only liberated once; we are only received once into the immortal kingdom. It is only once that “Happy is he whose fault is taken away, whose sin is covered.” Hold firm, then, to the gift received, safeguard your joy, and do not commit further sin. Preserve yourselves pure and innocent for the day of the Lord.

Responsorial. *Cfr. 1 Cor. 15: 47, 49; Col. 3: 9, 10*

R: The first man was taken from the earth, the second comes from heaven.

* As we have borne the image of the earthly man, so also will we bear the image of the heavenly man.

V: You have undressed yourselves of the old man with his actions and you have clothed yourselves with the new one, who is renewed in the image of his creator.

R: As we have borne the image of the earthly man, so also will we bear the image of the heavenly man.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *1 Tm. 5:3 – 25*

The widows. The presbyters.

A reading from the First Letter to Timothy of St. Paul, apostle.

Honour widows who are real widows. If a widow has children or grandchildren, let them first learn their religious duty to their own family and make some return to their parents; for this is acceptable in the sight of God. She who is a real widow, and is left all alone, has set her hope on God and continues in supplications and prayers night and day; whereas she who is self-indulgent is dead even while she lives. Command this, so that they may be without reproach. If any one does not provide for his relatives, and

especially for his own family, he has disowned the faith and is worse than an unbeliever.

Let a widow be enrolled if she is not less than sixty years of age, having been the wife of one husband; and she must be well attested for her good deeds, as one who has brought up children, shown hospitality, washed the feet of the saints, relieved the afflicted, and devoted herself to doing good in every way. But refuse to enrol younger widows; for when they grow wanton against Christ they desire to marry, and so they incur condemnation for having violated their first pledge. Besides that, they learn to be idlers, gadding about from house to house, and not only idlers but also gossips and busybodies, saying what they should not. So I would have younger widows marry, bear children, rule their households, and give the enemy no occasion to revile us. For some have already strayed after Satan. If any believing woman has relatives who are widows, let her assist them; let the church not be burdened, so that it may assist those who are real widows.

Let the elders who rule well be considered worthy of double honour, especially those who labour in preaching and teaching; for the scripture says, "You shall not muzzle an ox when it is treading out the grain," and, "The labourer deserves his wages." Never admit any charge against an elder except on the evidence of two or three witnesses. As for those who persist in sin, rebuke them in the presence of all, so that the rest may stand in fear. In the presence of God and of Christ Jesus and of the elect angels I charge you to keep these rules without favour, doing nothing from partiality.

Do not be hasty in the laying on of hands, nor participate in another man's sins; keep yourself pure.

No longer drink only water, but use a little wine for the sake of your stomach and your frequent ailments.

The sins of some men are conspicuous, pointing to judgement, but the sins of others appear later. So also good deeds are conspicuous; and even when they are not, they cannot remain hidden.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Phil. 1: 27; 2: 4, 5*

R: Behave in a way that is worthy of the gospel, fight unanimously for the faith, * without searching for your own interests, but that of the others.

V: Have in yourselves the same sentiments that were in Christ Jesus,

R: without searching for your own interests, but that of the others.

Second Reading. Nm. 1 -.3

In obedience to the bishop and to the college of presbyters.

The beginning of the “Letter to the Ephesians” of St. Ignatius of Antioch, bishop and martyr.

Ignatius, who is also called Theophorus, to the Church which is at Ephesus, in Asia, deservedly most happy, being blessed in the greatness and fullness of God the Father, and predestined before the beginning of time, that it should be always for an enduring and unchangeable glory, being united and elected through the true passion by the will of the Father, and Jesus Christ, our God: Abundant happiness through Jesus Christ, and His undefiled grace. I have become acquainted with your name, much-beloved in God, which you have acquired by the habit of righteousness, according to the faith and love in Jesus Christ our Saviour. Being the followers of God, and stirring up yourselves by the blood of Christ, you have perfectly accomplished the work that was suitable to you. For, on hearing that I came bound from Syria for the common name and hope, trusting through your prayers to be permitted to fight with beasts at Rome, that so by martyrdom I may indeed become the disciple of Him “who gave Himself for us, an offering and sacrifice to God,” [you hastened to see me]. I received, therefore, your whole multitude in the name of God, through Onesimus, a man of inexpressible love, and your bishop in the flesh, whom I pray you by Jesus Christ to love, and that you would all seek to be like him. And blessed be He who has granted unto you, being worthy, to obtain such an excellent bishop.

As to my fellow servant Burrhus, your deacon in regard to God and blessed in all things, I beg that he may continue longer, both for your honour and that of your bishop. And Crocus also, worthy both of God and you, whom I have received as the manifestation of your love, has in all things comforted me, as the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ shall also comfort him; together with Onesimus, and Burrhus, and Euplus, and Fronto, by means of whom, I have, as to love, beheld all of you. May I always have joy in you, if indeed I were worthy of it. It is therefore befitting that you should in every way glorify Jesus Christ, who has glorified you, that by a unanimous obedience “you may be perfectly joined together in the same mind, and in the same judgement, and may all speak the same thing

concerning the same thing,” and that, being subject to the bishop and the presbytery, you may in all respects be sanctified.

I do not issue orders to you, as if I were some great person. For though I am bound for the name [of Christ], I am not yet perfect in Jesus Christ. For now I begin to be a disciple and I speak to you as fellow disciples with me. For it was needful for me to have been stirred up by you in faith, exhortation, patience and long suffering. But inasmuch as love suffers me not to be silent in regard to you, I have therefore taken upon me first to exhort you that you would all run together in accordance with the will of the Father, as he himself says: “I always do the things that are pleasing to you” (Jn. 8: 29). For even Jesus Christ, our inseparable life, is the manifested will of the Father; as also the bishops, settled everywhere to the utmost bounds of the earth, are so by the will of Jesus Christ. And thus it is necessary that we also, according to the design of God, live in Christ and imitate him, as Paul says: “Make yourselves my imitators, as I am of Christ” (1 Cor. 11: 1).

Responsorial. *Ep. 15: 2; cfr. 1 Cor. 1: 10*

R: Walk in love, in the way that Christ himself has loved you and has given himself for you, * offering himself as a sweet smelling sacrifice to God.

V: All of you unanimous in speaking and in perfect union of thought and intent, glorify Jesus Christ who has glorified you,

R: offering himself as a sweet smelling sacrifice to God.

YEAR A

Gospel. *Mt. 16: 21-27*

If anyone wants to be a follower of mine, let him renounce himself.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

From that time Jesus began to show his disciples that he must go to Jerusalem and suffer many things from the elders and chief priests and scribes, and be killed, and on the third day be raised. And Peter took him and began to rebuke him, saying, "God forbid, Lord! This shall never happen to you." But he turned and said to Peter, "Get behind me, Satan! You are a hindrance to me; for you are not on the side of God, but of men."

Then Jesus told his disciples, "If any man would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me. For whoever would save his life will lose it, and whoever loses his life for my sake will find it. For what will it profit a man, if he gains the whole world and forfeits his life? Or what shall a man give in return for his life? For the Son of man is to come with his angels in the glory of his Father, and then he will repay every man for what he has done.

Third Reading. *Book. 5*

The Church follows Christ everywhere.

A reading from the treatise “On the adoration in spirit and truth” of St Cyril of Alexandria, bishop.

“If anyone wants to be a follower of mine, he must renounce himself, take up his cross and follow me” (Mt. 16: 24). That is: if someone wants to be a disciple, he must follow courageously the same way of suffering that I have followed, go along the same road and I will love him: then he will rest together with me and he will dwell with me; for us in fact he asked God the Father: “I want those you have given me to be with me where I am” (Jn. 17: 24). We are with Christ even when we dwell on the earth, living not according to the flesh but according to the Spirit, forcing ourselves to rest in that which pleases him. In the book of Numbers we find an image of this reality: when the holy tabernacle was raised up in the desert, a cloud filled it; and God commanded the sons of Israel to move and to stop together with the cloud, respecting diligently the times established for the departure: to those then who were tempted by laziness, he made them understand how dangerous it was to transgress this norm.

Let us try to penetrate the spiritual significance of these facts. When the true and perfect tabernacle that is the Church, was raised up and appeared on the earth, it was filled by the glory of Christ. This was meant to signify, in my opinion, the cloud that covered the old tabernacle.

With his glory the Christ has filled the Church and shines like a fire, emanating an immense spiritual light for those who are immersed in ignorance and in error, as though shrouded in the darkness of the night. For those instead who are already illuminated and in whose hearts shines the spiritual light, he emits a shadow and protection and he floods them with

the heavenly dew, that is with the supernatural consolations of the Spirit: this is why he appears as the fire by night and as a cloud by day.

He in fact who is at the beginning of the day, must be taught and illuminated in order to reach the knowledge of God. But he who is more advanced and already illuminated by the faith, needs the protection and the help to face with courage the trials of the present life and the weight of the day: in fact “ all those who want to live piously in Christ Jesus will be persecuted” (2 Tm. 3: 12). When the cloud moved the tabernacle also moved and, together with it the sons of Israel: thus the Church follows Christ everywhere, and the holy multitude of the believers never go far away from he who leads them to salvation.

Responsorial. *Gal. 6: 14; Hab. 3: 18*

R: As for me the only thing that I can boast about is the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, * through whom the world is crucified to me, and I to the world.

V: I will rejoice in the Lord, I will exult in God my saviour.

R: Through whom the world is crucified to me, and I to the world.

YEAR B

Gospel. *Mk. 7: 1-8, 14-15, 21-23*

You put aside the commandment of God to cling to human traditions.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Mark.

Now when the Pharisees gathered together to him, with some of the scribes, who had come from Jerusalem, they saw that some of his disciples ate with hands defiled, that is, unwashed. For the Pharisees, and all the Jews, do not eat unless they wash their hands, observing the tradition of the elders; and when they come from the market place, they do not eat unless they purify themselves; and there are many other traditions which they observe, the washing of cups and pots and vessels of bronze. And the Pharisees and the scribes asked him, "Why do your disciples not live according to the tradition of the elders, but eat with hands defiled?"

And he said to them, "Well did Isaiah prophesy of you hypocrites, as it is written, `This people honours me with their lips, but their heart is far from me; in vain do they worship me, teaching as doctrines the precepts of

men.' You leave the commandment of God, and hold fast the tradition of men."

And he called the people to him again, and said to them, "Hear me, all of you, and understand: there is nothing outside a man which by going into him can defile him; but the things which come out of a man are what defile him." For from within, out of the heart of man, come evil thoughts, fornication, theft, murder, adultery, coveting, wickedness, deceit, licentiousness, envy, slander, pride, foolishness. All these evil things come from within, and they defile a man."

Third Reading. *Book 4: 12, 1-13, 3*

The first and greatest precept of the law and of the gospel is the love of God.

A reading from the treatise "Against the heresies" of St. Irenaeus, bishop.

The tradition of the same elders, whom they feigned to observe as deriving from the law, was in contrast with the law given by Moses. For this Isaiah said: "**Your best wine is diluted with water**" (Is. 1: 22), showing that the elders had united a watered down tradition to the severe precept of God, that is falsified and contrary to the law, as the Lord showed clearly when he said: "Neglecting the commandment of God, you observe your tradition" (Mk. 7: 8, 9). And they evaded the law of God not only mixing the wine to the water, that is prevaricating; but also establishing their own law which was conflicting with that of God, that till today is called Pharisaic. In it they remove something, and they add something else, interpreting others in their own way: and their masters make use of all this, each one in his own way.

Wanting to claim responsibility for these traditions, they do not want to be subjected to the law of God that prepared them for the coming of the Christ, but they rebuked the Lord who cured on the Sabbath, a thing which was not prohibited by the law: this in fact was foreseen in certain cases, circumcising man on the Sabbath. But they did not rebuke themselves of transgressing the commandment of God for the tradition and for the above-mentioned Pharisaic law, not taking into account the principal precept of the law, that is of the love towards God. Since this is the first and greatest commandment, and the second is the love of the neighbour; the Lord taught that all the law and the prophets were included in these two precepts (cfr.

Mt 23: 37). He himself then did not come to bring a precept greater than this, but he renewed it, ordering his disciples to love God with all the heart and the others as themselves. St. Paul also says that “complete fulfilment of the law is love” (Rm. 13: 10); and when all things will finish, “faith hope and charity will remain; but of all of these the greatest is love” (1 Cor. 13: 13). Nor is science without love worth anything in front of God, nor the understanding of mysteries, nor faith, nor prophecy: all things are empty and vain without love. To achieve love instead, makes man perfect, and he who loves God is perfect in this time and in the future; in fact loving God we do not perish, but the more we will have contemplated him, the more we will love him.

It is clear that the author of the law and of the Gospel is the same, since in both the first and greatest commandment is to love God with all the heart, and the second, to love the neighbour as one self, is similar to the first. Therefore the commandments of life summed up as much in the New as in the Old Testament, being the same, manifest the same God; who commanded the particular precepts suited to both the Testaments, while the more important and sublime, without which we cannot be saved, he prescribed as much in one as in the other.

Responsorial. *Deut. 10: 12; Mt. 22:38*

R: What does the Lord your God ask of you? * That you fear the Lord your God, that you love him and serve the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul.

V: This is the greatest and the first of the commandments:

R: That you fear the Lord your God, that you love him and serve the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul.

YEAR C

Gospel. *Lk. 14: 1, 7- 14*

*Everyone who exalts himself will be humbled,
and the man who humbles himself will be exalted.*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

One Sabbath when he went to dine at the house of a ruler who belonged to the Pharisees, they were watching him. Now he told a parable

to those who were invited, when he marked how they chose the places of honour, saying to them, "When you are invited by any one to a marriage feast, do not sit down in a place of honour, lest a more eminent man than you be invited by him; and he who invited you both will come and say to you, 'Give place to this man,' and then you will begin with shame to take the lowest place. But when you are invited, go and sit in the lowest place, so that when your host comes he may say to you, 'Friend, go up higher'; then you will be honoured in the presence of all who sit at table with you. For every one who exalts himself will be humbled, and he who humbles himself will be exalted."

He said also to the man who had invited him, "When you give a dinner or a banquet, do not invite your friends or your brothers or your kinsmen or rich neighbours, lest they also invite you in return, and you be repaid. But when you give a feast, invite the poor, the maimed, the lame, the blind, and you will be blessed, because they cannot repay you. You will be repaid at the resurrection of the just."

Third Reading. Vol. 1, 78- 80

True humility.

A reading from the "Discourse on the Annunciation of the Lord" of St. Aelred, abbot.

In truth, brothers, there cannot be true humility in us if it is not nourished by a healthy fear, nor obedience if it is not rendered sweet by the spirit of piety, nor justice if it is not supported by the science of the Spirit, nor patience if it is not sustained by the spirit of strength, nor mercy if it is not illuminated by counsel, nor pureness of heart if it is not preserved by the heavenly things, nor charity if it is not vivified by the wisdom which is the taste for the things of God.

All this is found in its fullness only in Christ, in whom is all the good and not only in part. He manifested humility in his birth because "he undressed himself, assuming the condition of a servant and becoming similar to men he appeared in human form" (Phil 2: 7).

In the submission to the parents he showed obedience when, abandoning that which was dear to his heart, "he returned to Nazareth and was subjected to them" (Lk. 2: 51). In his doctrine then he did not neglect

justice saying: “Render to Caesar what belongs to Caesar, and to God what belongs to God”.

In the passion above all he showed patience in an eminent way, offering his back to the whips, his face to the spittle, his head to the thorns, the hand to the cane; and in all these things, as the prophet said: “he did not cry out or shout aloud, or make his voice heard in the streets” (Is. 42: 2), because “he was like a sheep led to the slaughter, like a lamb dumb in front of its shearers, he did not open his mouth” (Is. 53: 7).

The blind men then to whom he gave back their sight, the lepers that he healed, the dead resurrected by him, and particularly the adulterous woman whom he pardoned, the repentant sinner whom he welcomed, the paralytic whose sins he forgave: all these experienced his mercy.

But since there is no greater proof of charity than the love towards the enemies, of the good that is done to those who hate us and of the help that we offer to those who calumniate us, we can measure his love by those words that he uttered while dying on the cross when he prayed for his own murderers: “Father, forgive them, because they do not know what they are doing” (Lk. 23: 34).

Therefore, brothers, the Holy Spirit has infused into our hearts his fear: so that meditating continuously on it as though masticating a healthy food, our interior humility may grow stronger; let us pray to him that we may not clothe only our external behaviour, but let us act in a way that we do not accomplish good only in order to be seen by men.

Responsorial. *1 Pet. 5: 5; Mt. 11: 29*

R: All of you wrap yourselves in humility to be servants of each other * because God refuses the proud and will always favour the humble.

V: Learn from me for I am gentle and humble of heart and you will find rest for your souls;

R: because God refuses the proud and will always favour the humble.

MONDAY

CYCLE I

First Reading: *Amos 1:1-2:3*

The judgement of God on the nations.

A reading from the prophet Amos.

The words of Amos, who was among the shepherds of Teko'a, which he saw concerning Israel in the days of Uzzi'ah king of Judah and in the days of Jerobo'am the son of Jo'ash, king of Israel, two years before the earthquake.

And he said: "The LORD roars from Zion, and utters his voice from Jerusalem; the pastures of the shepherds mourn, and the top of Carmel withers."

Thus says the LORD: "For three transgressions of Damascus, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment; because they have threshed Gilead with threshing sledges of iron. So I will send a fire upon the house of Haz'ael, and it shall devour the strongholds of Ben-ha'dad. I will break the bar of Damascus, and cut off the inhabitants from the Valley of Aven, and him that holds the sceptre from Beth-eden; and the people of Syria shall go into exile to Kir," says the LORD.

Thus says the LORD: "For three transgressions of Gaza, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment; because they carried into exile a whole people to deliver them up to Edom. So I will send a fire upon the wall of Gaza, and it shall devour her strongholds. I will cut off the inhabitants from Ashdod, and him that holds the sceptre from Ash'kelon; I will turn my hand against Ekron; and the remnant of the Philistines shall perish," says the Lord GOD.

Thus says the LORD: "For three transgressions of Tyre, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment; because they delivered up a whole people to Edom, and did not remember the covenant of brotherhood. So I will send a fire upon the wall of Tyre, and it shall devour her strongholds."

Thus says the LORD: "For three transgressions of Edom, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment; because he pursued his brother with the sword, and cast off all pity, and his anger tore perpetually, and he kept his wrath for ever. So I will send a fire upon Teman, and it shall devour the strongholds of Bozrah."

Thus says the LORD: "For three transgressions of the Ammonites, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment; because they have ripped up women with child in Gilead, that they might enlarge their border. So I will kindle a fire in the wall of Rabbah, and it shall devour her strongholds, with shouting in the day of battle, with a tempest in the day of the whirlwind;

and their king shall go into exile, he and his princes together," says the LORD.

Thus says the LORD: "For three transgressions of Moab, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment; because he burned to lime the bones of the king of Edom. So I will send a fire upon Moab, and it shall devour the strongholds of Ker'ioth, and Moab shall die amid uproar, amid shouting and the sound of the trumpet; I will cut off the ruler from its midst, and will slay all its princes with him," says the LORD.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Ps. 9: 8, 9; Am. 1: 2*

R: The Lord has established his throne for the judgement: he will judge the world with justice, * he will decide with uprightness the cause of the nations.

V: The Lord roars from Zion, from Jerusalem he makes his voice heard:

R: he will decide with uprightness the cause of the nations.

Second Reading. *C. 1: 1*

The hope of life is the beginning and the end of our faith.

A reading from the "Letter", attributed to Barnabas.

All hail, you sons and daughters, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ who loved us in peace. Seeing the divine fruits of righteousness abound among you, I rejoice exceedingly and above measure in your happy and honoured spirits because you have with such effect received the engrafted spiritual gift. Wherefore also I inwardly rejoice the more, hoping to be saved, because I truly perceive in you the Spirit poured forth from the rich Lord of love. Your greatly desired appearance has thus filled me with astonishment over you.

I am therefore persuaded of this, and fully convinced in my own mind, that since I began to speak among you I understand many things, because the Lord has accompanied me in the way of righteousness. I am also on this account bound by the strictest obligation to love you above my own soul, because great are the faith and love dwelling in you, while you hope for the life which He has promised. Considering this, therefore, that if I should take the trouble to communicate to you some portion of what I

have myself received, it will prove to me a sufficient reward that I minister to such spirits, I have hastened briefly to write to you, in order that, along with your faith, you might have things as we see accomplished, one by one, we may put you in complete possession of perfect knowledge.

The doctrines of the Lord then are three: the hope of life, the beginning and the completion of it.

For the Lord has made known to us by the prophets both the things of the past and present, giving us also the first fruits of the knowledge of things to come which ought with the greater richness of faith and elevation of spirit to draw near to Him with reverence. I then, not as your teacher, but as one of yourselves, will set forth a few things by which in present circumstances you may be rendered the more joyful.

Since, therefore, the days are evil, and Satan possesses the power of this world, we ought to give heed to ourselves, and diligently inquire into the ordinances of the Lord. Fear and patience, then, are helpers of our faith; and long-suffering and continence are things that fight on our side. While these remain pure in what respects the Lord, Wisdom, Understanding, Science, and Knowledge rejoice along with them.

For He has revealed to us by all the prophets that He needs neither sacrifices, nor burnt offerings, nor oblations, saying thus, "What is the multitude of your sacrifices unto Me, says the Lord? I am full of burnt-offerings, and desire not the fat of lambs, and the blood of bulls and goats, not when you come to appear before Me: for who has required these things at your hands? Tread no more my courts, not though you bring with you fine flour. Incense is a vain abomination unto me, and your new moons and Sabbaths I cannot endure."

Responsorial. *Cfr. Gal. 2: 16; Gen. 15: 6*

R: We know that man is justified only through faith: * we have believed, in order to be justified by faith in Christ.

V: Abraham believed in the Lord, and this was accredited to him as justice;

R: we have believed in order to be justified by faith in Christ.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *1 Tm. 6: 1 – 10*

The servants. The false doctors.

A reading from the First Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to Timothy.

Let all who are under the yoke of slavery regard their masters as worthy of all honour, so that the name of God and the teaching may not be defamed. Those who have believing masters must not be disrespectful on the ground that they are brethren; rather they must serve all the better since those who benefit by their service are believers and beloved. Teach and urge these duties.

If any one teaches otherwise and does not agree with the sound words of our Lord Jesus Christ and the teaching which accords with godliness, he is puffed up with conceit, he knows nothing; he has a morbid craving for controversy and for disputes about words, which produce envy, dissension, slander, base suspicions, and wrangling among men who are depraved in mind and bereft of the truth, imagining that godliness is a means of gain.

There is great gain in godliness with contentment; for we brought nothing into the world, and we cannot take anything out of the world; but if we have food and clothing, with these we shall be content. But those who desire to be rich fall into temptation, into a snare, into many senseless and hurtful desires that plunge men into ruin and destruction. For the love of money is the root of all evils; it is through this craving that some have wandered away from the faith and pierced their hearts with many pangs.

Responsorial. *Mt. 6: 25; 1 Tm. 6: 8*

R: Do not worry about what you are to eat, and neither about what you are to wear: * is not life worth more than food and the body more than clothing?

V: As long as we have food and clothing, let us be content with that:

R: is not life worth more than food and the body more than clothing?

Second Reading. Nm. 4 – 6

*Remain in an irreproachable unity,
make yourselves only one thing with God.*

A reading from the “Letter to the Ephesians” of St. Ignatius of Antioch, bishop and martyr.

Wherefore it is fitting that you should run together in accordance with the will of your bishop, which thing also you do. For your justly renowned presbytery, worthy of God, is fitted as exactly to the bishop as the strings are to the harp. Therefore in your concord and harmonious love, Jesus Christ is sung. And do you, man by man, become a choir, that being harmonious in love, and taking up the song of God in unison, you may with one voice sing to the Father through Jesus Christ, so that He may both hear you, and perceive by your works that you are indeed the members of His Son. It is profitable, therefore, that you should live in an un-blameable unity, that thus you may always enjoy communion with God.

For if I in this brief space of time, have enjoyed such fellowship with your bishop — I mean not of a mere human, but of a spiritual nature — how much more do I reckon you happy who are so joined to him as the Church is to Jesus Christ, and as Jesus Christ is to the Father, that so all things may agree in unity! Let no man deceive himself: if any one be not within the sanctuary, he is deprived of the bread of God. For if the prayer of one or two possesses such power, how much more that of the bishop and the whole Church! He therefore, that does not assemble with the Church, has even by this manifested his pride, and condemned himself. For it is written, “God resists the proud.” Let us be careful, then, not to set ourselves in opposition to the bishop, in order that we may be subject to God.

The more therefore, you see the bishop silent, the more do you revere him. For we ought to receive every one whom the Master of the house sends to be over His household, as we would do Him that sent him. It is manifest, therefore, that we should look upon the bishop even as we would look upon the Lord Himself, standing, as he does, before the Lord. And

indeed Onesimus himself greatly commends your good order in God, that you all live according to the truth, and that no sect has any dwelling-place among you. Nor indeed do you listen to any one rather than to Jesus Christ, the true Shepherd and Teacher. And you are, as Paul wrote to you, "one body and one spirit, because you have also been called in one hope of the faith. Since also "there is one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of all, who is over all, and through all, and in all." Such, then, are you, having been taught by such instructors, Paul the Christ-bearer, and Timothy the most faithful.

Responsorial. Ep. 4: 1, 3-4

R: I exhort you in the Lord to behave in a manner that is worthy of the vocation that you have received: * Preserve the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.

V: Only one body, only one Spirit, as only one is the hope to which you have been called.

R. Preserve the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.

Gospel. Lk. 4:16 – 30

He has sent me to announce the good news to the poor

No prophet is welcome in his own country.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

And he came to Nazareth, where he had been brought up; and he went to the synagogue, as his custom was, on the Sabbath day. And he stood up to read; and there was given to him the book of the prophet Isaiah. He opened the book and found the place where it was written,

"The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim release to the captives and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed, to proclaim the acceptable year of the Lord." And he closed the book, and gave it back to the attendant, and sat down; and the eyes of all in the synagogue were fixed on him. And he began to say to them, "Today this scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing." And all spoke well of him, and wondered at the gracious words that proceeded out of his mouth; and they said, "Is not this Joseph's son?" And he said to them, "Doubtless you will quote to me this proverb, 'Physician, heal yourself; what we have

heard you did at Caper'na-um, do here also in your own country.'" And he said, "Truly, I say to you, no prophet is acceptable in his own country.

But in truth, I tell you, there were many widows in Israel in the days of Eli'jah, when the heaven was shut up three years and six months, when there came a great famine over all the land; and Eli'jah was sent to none of them but only to Zar'ephath, in the land of Sidon, to a woman who was a widow. And there were many lepers in Israel in the time of the prophet Eli'sha; and none of them was cleansed, but only Na'aman the Syrian."

When they heard this, all in the synagogue were filled with wrath. And they rose up and put him out of the city, and led him to the brow of the hill on which their city was built, that they might throw him down headlong. But passing through the midst of them he went away.

TUESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Am. 2:4 – 16*

The judgement of God on Judah and Israel.

A reading from the prophet Amos.

Thus says the LORD: "For three transgressions of Judah, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment; because they have rejected the law of the LORD, and have not kept his statutes, but their lies have led them astray, after which their fathers walked. So I will send a fire upon Judah, and it shall devour the strongholds of Jerusalem."

Thus says the LORD: "For three transgressions of Israel, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment; because they sell the righteous for silver, and the needy for a pair of shoes -- they that trample the head of the poor into the dust of the earth, and turn aside the way of the afflicted; a man and his father go in to the same maiden, so that my holy name is profaned; they lay themselves down beside every altar upon garments taken in pledge; and in the house of their God they drink the wine of those who have been fined. "Yet I destroyed the Amorite before them, whose height was like the height of the cedars, and who was as strong as the oaks; I destroyed his fruit above, and his roots beneath. Also I brought you up out of the land of Egypt, and led you forty years in the wilderness, to possess the land of the Amorite. And I raised up some of your sons for prophets, and some of your young men for Nazirites. Is it not indeed so, O people of Israel?" says the LORD. "But you made the Nazirites drink wine, and commanded the prophets, saying, 'You shall not prophesy.' "Behold, I will press you down in your place, as a cart full of sheaves presses down. Flight shall perish from the swift, and the strong shall not retain his strength, nor shall the mighty save his life; he who handles the bow shall not stand, and he who is swift of foot shall not save himself, nor shall he who rides the horse save his life; and he who is stout of heart among the mighty shall flee away naked in that day," says the LORD.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Am. 2: 10, 11, 12; Ps. 94: 10*

R: I am the one who has made you come out of the land of Egypt and who has led you for forty years in the desert. And I said: * they are a people with

a crooked heart, they do not know my ways.

V: I raised up prophets among your children, and to the prophets I had ordered: do not prophesy!

R: They are a people with a crooked heart, they do not know my ways.

Second Reading. Cc. 2: 6 – 10; 3: 1, 3, 4, 10 – 16

The new law of our Lord.

A reading from the “Letter” attributed to Barnabas.

He has therefore abolished the old sacrifices, so that the new law of our Lord Jesus Christ, which is without the yoke of constriction, might have an offering that is not work of men. And again He says to them, “Did I command your fathers, when they went out from the land of Egypt, to offer unto me burnt-offerings and sacrifices? But this rather I commanded them, Let no one of you cherish any evil in his heart against his neighbour, and love not an oath of falsehood.” We ought therefore, being possessed of understanding, to perceive the gracious intention of our Father; for He speaks to us, desirous that we, not going astray like them, should ask how we may approach Him. To us, then, He declares, “A sacrifice [pleasing] to God is a broken spirit; a smell of sweet savour to the Lord is a heart that glorifies Him that made it.” We ought therefore, brethren, carefully to inquire concerning our salvation, lest the Wicked one, having made his entrance by deceit, should hurl us forth from our [true] life. He says then to them again concerning these things, “Why do you fast to me as on this day, says the Lord, that your voice should be heard with a cry? I have not chosen this fast, says the Lord, that a man should humble his soul? Is it to bend your neck like a reed, and put upon you sackcloth and ashes? Will you call it an acceptable fast.” To us He says,

“Behold, this is the fast that I have chosen, says the Lord, not that a man should humble his soul, but that he should loose every band of iniquity, untie the fastenings of harsh agreements, restore to liberty them that are bruised, tear in pieces every unjust engagement, feed the hungry with your bread, clothe the naked when you see him, bring the homeless into your house, let us utterly hate the works of the way of wickedness. Do not, by retiring apart, live a solitary life, as if you were already [fully] justified; but coming together in one place, make common inquiry concerning what tends to your general welfare. For the Scripture says, “Woe to them who are wise

to themselves, and prudent in their own sight!” Let us be spiritually minded: let us be a perfect temple to God. As much as in us lies, let us meditate upon the fear of God, and let us keep His commandments, that we may rejoice in His ordinances. The Lord will judge the world without respect of persons. Each will receive as he has done: if he is righteous, his righteousness will precede him; if he is wicked, the reward of wickedness is before him. Take heed, lest resting at our ease, as those who are the called [of God], we should fall asleep in our sins, and the wicked prince, acquiring power over us, should thrust us away from the kingdom of the Lord. And all the more attend to this, my brethren, when you reflect and behold, that after so great signs and wonders were wrought in Israel, they were thus [at length] abandoned. Let us beware lest we be found [fulfilling that saying], as it is written, “Many are called, but few are chosen.”

Responsorial. *Cfr. Gal. 3: 24, 25, 23*

R: The Law was to be our guardian until the Christ came and we could be justified by faith. * Now that the faith has come we are no longer under the law.

V: Before faith came, we were allowed no freedom by the Law; we were being looked after till faith was revealed.

R: Now that the faith has come we are no longer under the law.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *1 Tm. 6: 11 – 21*

Final exhortations.

A reading from the First Letter to Timothy of St. Paul, apostle.

But as for you, man of God, shun all this; aim at righteousness, godliness, faith, love, steadfastness, and gentleness. Fight the good fight of the faith; take hold of the eternal life to which you were called when you made the good confession in the presence of many witnesses. In the presence of God who gives life to all things, and of Christ Jesus who in his testimony before Pontius Pilate made the good confession, I charge you to keep the commandment unstained and free from reproach until the appearing of our Lord Jesus Christ; and this will be made manifest at the

proper time by the blessed and only Sovereign, the King of kings and Lord of lords, who alone has immortality and dwells in unapproachable light, whom no man has ever seen or can see. To him be honour and eternal dominion. Amen.

As for the rich in this world, charge them not to be haughty, nor to set their hopes on uncertain riches but on God who richly furnishes us with everything to enjoy. They are to do good, to be rich in good deeds, liberal and generous, thus laying up for themselves a good foundation for the future, so that they may take hold of the life which is life indeed.

O Timothy, guard what has been entrusted to you. Avoid the godless chatter and contradictions of what is falsely called knowledge, for by professing it some have missed the mark as regards the faith. Grace be with you.

Responsorial. *Col. 2: 6, 7; Mt. 6: 19-20*

R: Walk in the Lord Jesus Christ, as you have received him, firm in the faith that has been taught to you, * full of thanksgiving.

V: Do not gather treasures for yourselves on earth, gather treasures instead in heaven,

R: full of thanksgiving.

Second Reading. *Nm. 7 – 9*

Do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ.

A reading from the “Letter to the Ephesians” of St. Ignatius of Antioch, bishop and martyr.

But some most worthless persons are in the habit of carrying about the name [of Jesus Christ] in wicked guile, while yet they practice things unworthy of God, and hold opinions contrary to the doctrine of Christ, to their own destruction, and that of those who give credit to them, whom you must avoid as you would wild beasts. For “the righteous man who avoids them is saved for ever; but the destruction of the ungodly is sudden, and a subject of rejoicing.” For “they are dumb dogs, that cannot bark,” raving mad, and biting secretly, against whom you must be on your guard, since they labour under an incurable disease. But our Physician is the only true God, the unbegotten and unapproachable, the Lord of all, the Father and Begetter of the only-begotten Son. We have also as a Physician the Lord our

God, Jesus the Christ, the only begotten Son and Word, before time began, but who afterwards became also man, of Mary the virgin. For “the Word was made flesh.” Being incorporeal, He was in the body; being impassable, He was in a passable body; being immortal, He was in a mortal body; being life, He became subject to corruption, that He might free our souls from death and corruption, and heal them, and might restore them to health, when they were diseased with ungodliness and wicked lusts.

Let not then any one deceive you, as indeed you are not deceived; for you are wholly devoted to God. For when there is no evil desire within you, which might defile and torment you, then do you live in accordance with the will of God, and are [the servants] of Christ. Cast out that which defiles you, who are of the most holy Church of the Ephesians, which is so famous and celebrated throughout the world. They that are carnal cannot do those things that are spiritual, or they that are spiritual the things which are carnal; even as faith cannot do the works of unbelief, nor unbelief the works of faith. But you, being full of the Holy Spirit, do nothing according to the flesh, but all things according to the Spirit. You are complete in Christ Jesus, “who is the Saviour of all men, specially of them that believe.”

Nevertheless, I have heard of some who have passed in among you, holding the wicked doctrine of the strange and evil spirit; to whom you did not allow entrance to sow their discord but stopped your ears that you might not receive that error which was proclaimed by them, as being persuaded that that spirit which deceives the people does not speak the things of Christ, but his own, for he is a lying spirit. But the Holy Spirit does not speak His own things, but those of Christ, and that not from himself, but from the Lord; even as the Lord also announced to us the things that He received from the Father. For, says He, “the word that you hear is not mine, but the Father’s, who sent me.” And says He of the Holy Spirit, “He shall not speak of Himself, but whatsoever things He shall hear from me.” And He says of Himself to the Father, “I have,” says He, “glorified You upon the earth; I have finished the work which, You gave Me; I have manifested Your name to men.” And of the Holy Spirit, “He shall glorify me, for He receives of mine.” But the spirit of deceit preaches himself, and speaks his own things, for he seeks to please himself. He glorifies himself, for he is full of arrogance. He is lying, fraudulent, soothing, flattering, treacherous, rhapsodical, trifling, inharmonious, verbose, sordid, and timorous. From his power Jesus Christ will deliver you, who has founded you upon the rock, as

being chosen stones, well fitted for the divine edifice of the Father, and who are raised up on high by Christ, who was crucified for you, making use of the Holy Spirit as a rope, and being borne up by faith, while exalted by love from earth to heaven, walking in company with those that are undefiled. For, says [the Scripture], "Blessed are the undefiled in the way, who walk in the law of the Lord." Now the way is unerring, namely, Jesus Christ. For, says He, "I am the way and the life." And this way leads to the Father. For "no man," says He, "comes to the Father but by me." Blessed, then, are you who are God-bearers, spirit-bearers, temple-bearers, bearers of holiness, adorned in all respects with the commandments of Jesus Christ, being "a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people that God has acquired," on whose account I rejoice exceedingly, and have had the privilege, by this Epistle, of conversing with "the saints which are at Ephesus, the faithful in Christ Jesus." I rejoice, therefore, over you, that you do not give heed to vanity, and love nothing according to the flesh, but according to God.

Responsorial. *Col. 3: 17; 1 Cor. 10: 31*

R: All that you do in words and deeds * do it all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks through him to God the Father.

V: Do everything for the glory of God.

R: Do it all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks through him to God the Father.

Gospel. *Lk. 4:31 – 37*

I know who you are. The Holy One of God.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

And he went down to Caper'na-um, a city of Galilee. And he was teaching them on the Sabbath; and they were astonished at his teaching, for his word was with authority.

And in the synagogue there was a man who had the spirit of an unclean demon; and he cried out with a loud voice, "Ah! What have you to do with us, Jesus of Nazareth? Have you come to destroy us? I know who you are, the Holy One of God." But Jesus rebuked him, saying, "Be silent, and come out of him!" And when the demon had thrown him down in the midst, he came out of him, having done him no harm. And they were all amazed and said to one another, "What is this word? For with authority and

power he commands the unclean spirits, and they come out." And reports of him went out into every place in the surrounding region.

WEDNESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Am. 3: 1 – 15*

The visit of the Lord in Samaria and Bethel.

A reading from the prophet Amos.

Hear this word that the LORD has spoken against you, O people of Israel, against the whole family which I brought up out of the land of Egypt:

"You only have I known of all the families of the earth; therefore I will punish you for all your iniquities.

"Do two walk together, unless they have made an appointment? Does a lion roar in the forest, when he has no prey? Does a young lion cry out from his den, if he has taken nothing? Does a bird fall in a snare on the earth, when there is no trap for it? Does a snare spring up from the ground, when it has taken nothing? Is a trumpet blown in a city, and the people are not afraid? Does evil befall a city, unless the LORD has done it? Surely the Lord GOD does nothing, without revealing his secret to his servants the prophets. The lion has roared; who will not fear? The Lord GOD has spoken; who can but prophesy?"

Proclaim to the strongholds in Assyria, and to the strongholds in the land of Egypt, and say, "Assemble yourselves upon the mountains of Sama'ria, and see the great tumults within her, and the oppressions in her midst." "They do not know how to do right," says the LORD, "those who store up violence and robbery in their strongholds." Therefore thus says the Lord GOD: "An adversary shall surround the land, and bring down your defences from you, and your strongholds shall be plundered." Thus says the LORD: "As the shepherd rescues from the mouth of the lion two legs, or a piece of an ear, so shall the people of Israel who dwell in Sama'ria be rescued, with the corner of a couch and part of a bed."

"Hear, and testify against the house of Jacob," says the Lord GOD, the God of hosts, "that on the day I punish Israel for his transgressions, I will punish the altars of Bethel, and the horns of the altar shall be cut off and fall to the ground. I will smite the winter house with the summer house; and the houses of ivory shall perish, and the great houses shall come to an end," says the LORD.

Responsorial. *Am. 3: 8, 1, 2*

R: The lion roars, who can help feeling afraid? * The Lord God has spoken: who can refuse to prophesy?

V: Listen to these words that the Lord has said regarding you, Israelites: I will make you pay for all your iniquities.

R: The Lord God has spoken: who can refuse to prophesy?

Second Reading. *C. 5: 1 – 8; 6: 11 – 16*

A new creation.

A reading from the “Letter” attributed to Barnabas.

For to this end the Lord endured to deliver up His flesh to death, that we might be sanctified through the remission of sins, which is effected by His blood of sprinkling. For it is written concerning Him, partly with reference to Israel, and partly to us; and [the Scripture] says thus: “He was wounded for our transgressions, and bruised for our iniquities: with His stripes we are healed. He was brought as a sheep to the slaughter, and as a lamb which is dumb before its shearer.”

Therefore we ought to be deeply grateful to the Lord, because He has both made known to us things that are past, and has given us wisdom concerning things present, and has not left us without understanding in regard to things which are to come. Now, the Scripture says, “Not unjustly are nets spread out for birds.” This means that the man perishes justly, who, having a knowledge of the way of righteousness, rushes off into the way of darkness. And further, my brethren: if the Lord endured to suffer for our soul, He being Lord of all the world, to whom God said at the foundation of the world, “Let us make man after our image, and after our likeness,” understand how it was that He endured to suffer at the hand of men. The prophets, having obtained grace from Him, prophesied concerning Him. And He (since he had to appear in flesh), that He might abolish death, and reveal the resurrection from the dead, endured [what and as He did], in order that He might fulfil the promise made unto the fathers, and by preparing a new people for Himself, might show, while He dwelt on earth, that He, when He has raised mankind, will also judge them.

Since, therefore, having renewed us by the remission of our sins, He has made us after another pattern, [it is His purpose] that we should possess

the soul of children, inasmuch as He has created us anew by His Spirit. For the Scripture says concerning us, while He speaks to the Son, "Let Us make man after our image, and after our likeness; and let them have dominion over the beasts of the earth, and the fowls of heaven, and the fishes of the sea." And the Lord said, on beholding the fair creature man, "Increase, and multiply, and replenish the earth." These things [were spoken] to the Son. Again, I will show you how, in respect to us, He has accomplished a second fashioning in these last days. The Lord says, "Behold, I will make the last like the first." In reference to this then, the prophet proclaimed, "Enter into the land flowing with milk and honey, and have dominion over it." Behold, therefore, we have been refashioned, as again He says in another prophet, "Behold, says the Lord, I will take away from these, that is, from those whom the Spirit of the Lord foresaw, their stony hearts, and I will put hearts of flesh within them," because He was to be manifested in flesh, and to sojourn among us. For, my brethren, the habitation of our heart is a holy temple to the Lord. For again says the Lord, "And wherewith shall I appear before the Lord my God, and be glorified?" He says, "I will confess to you in the Church in the midst of my brethren; and I will praise you in the midst of the assembly of the saints." We, then, are they whom He has led into the good land.

Responsorial. *Act. 3: 25; Gal. 3: 8*

R: You are the children of the prophets and of the covenant that God established with your fathers, when he said to Abraham: * In your descendants all the families of the earth will be blessed.

V: The Scriptures, foreseeing that God would justify the pagans through faith, pre-announced to Abraham:

R: In your descendants all the families of the earth will be blessed.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *2 Tm. 1: 1 – 18*

Paul exhorts Timothy to be strong in his duties.

A reading from the Second Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to Timothy.

Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God according to the promise of the life which is in Christ Jesus, To Timothy, my beloved child: Grace, mercy, and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord. I thank God whom I serve with a clear conscience, as did my fathers, when I remember you constantly in my prayers. As I remember your tears, I long night and day to see you, that I may be filled with joy. I am reminded of your sincere faith, a faith that dwelt first in your grandmother Lo'is and your mother Eunice and now, I am sure, dwells in you.

Hence I remind you to rekindle the gift of God that is within you through the laying on of my hands; for God did not give us a spirit of timidity but a spirit of power and love and self-control. Do not be ashamed then of testifying to our Lord, nor of me his prisoner, but share in suffering for the gospel in the power of God, who saved us and called us with a holy calling, not in virtue of our works but in virtue of his own purpose and the grace which he gave us in Christ Jesus ages ago, and now has manifested through the appearing of our Saviour Christ Jesus, who abolished death and brought life and immortality to light through the gospel.

For this gospel I was appointed a preacher and apostle and teacher, and therefore I suffer as I do. But I am not ashamed, for I know whom I have believed, and I am sure that he is able to guard until that Day what has been entrusted to me.

Follow the pattern of the sound words that you have heard from me, in the faith and love which are in Christ Jesus; guard the truth that has been entrusted to you by the Holy Spirit who dwells within us.

You are aware that all who are in Asia turned away from me, and among them Phy'gelus and Hermog'enes. May the Lord grant mercy to the household of Onesiph'orus, for he often refreshed me; he was not ashamed of my chains, but when he arrived in Rome he searched for me eagerly and found me --may the Lord grant him to find mercy from the Lord on that Day -- and you well know all the service he rendered at Ephesus.

Responsorial. *Rm. 8: 15-16; 2 Tm. 1: 7*

R: You have not received a spirit of slavery to fall back into fear, but you have received a spirit of adopted sons through which we cry: Abba, Father!
* The Spirit himself bears witness to our spirit that we are children of God.

V: God in fact has not given us a spirit of timidity, but of strength, of love and of wisdom.

R: The Spirit himself bears witness to our spirit that we are children of God.

Second Reading. *Nm. 10 – 12*

You are ministers of God and the mouth of Christ.

A reading from the “Letter to the Ephesians” of St. Ignatius of Antioch, bishop and martyr.

And pray without ceasing on behalf of other men; for there is hope of the repentance, that they may attain to God. For “cannot he that falls arise again, and he that goes astray return?” Permit them, then, to be instructed by you. Be therefore the ministers of God, and the mouth of Christ. For thus says the Lord, “If you take forth the precious from the vile, you shall be as my mouth.” Be humble in response to their wrath; oppose their blasphemies your earnest prayers; while they go astray, stand steadfast in the faith. Conquer their harsh temper by gentleness, their passion by meekness. For “blessed are the meek;” and Moses was meek above all men; and David was exceeding meek. Wherefore Paul exhorts as follows: “The servant of the Lord must not strive, but be gentle towards all men, apt to teach, patient, in meekness instructing those that oppose” Do not seek to avenge yourselves on those that injure you, for says [the Scripture], “If I have returned evil to those who returned evil to me.” Let us make them brethren by our kindness. For say to those that hate you; You are our brethren, that the name of the Lord may be glorified. And let us imitate the Lord, “who, when He was reviled, suffered, He threatened not;” but prayed for His enemies, “Father, forgive them; they know not what they do.” If any one, the more he is injured, displays the more patience, blessed is he. If any one is defrauded, if any one is despised, for the name of the Lord, he truly is the servant of Christ. Take heed that no plant of the devil is found among you, for such a plant is bitter and sour. “Watch, and be sober,” in Christ Jesus.

The last times are come upon us. Let us therefore be of a reverent spirit, and fear the long-suffering of God, lest we despise the riches of His

goodness and forbearance. For let us either fear the wrath to come, or let us love the present joy in the life that now is; and let our present and true joy be only this, to be found in Christ Jesus, that we may truly live. Do not at any time desire so much as even to breathe apart from Him. For He is my hope; He is my boast; He is my never-failing riches, on whose account I bear about with me these bonds from Syria to Rome, these spiritual jewels, in which may I be perfected through your prayers, and become a partaker of the sufferings of Christ, and have fellowship with Him in His death, His resurrection from the dead, and His everlasting life. May I attain to this, so that I may be found in the lot of the Christians of Ephesus, who have by the virtue of Jesus Christ been always obedient to the apostles, to Paul, to John and to the most faithful Timothy.

I know both who I am, and to whom I write. I am the very insignificant Ignatius, who have my lot with those who are exposed to danger and condemnation. But you have been the objects of mercy, and are established in Christ. I am one delivered over [to death], but the least of all those that have been cut off for the sake of Christ, “from the blood of righteous Abel” to the blood of Ignatius. You are initiated into the mysteries of the Gospel with Paul, the holy, the martyred, inasmuch as he was “a chosen vessel;” at whose feet may I be found, and at the feet of the rest of the saints, when I shall attain to Jesus Christ, who is always mindful of you in His prayers.

Responsorial. 2 Cor. 3: 4, 6, 5

R: This is the faith that we have through Christ, in front of God, * that he has made us suitable ministers of a New Covenant, not of letters, but of the Spirit.

V: Not however that we ourselves are capable of thinking something as coming from ourselves, but our capacity comes from God.

R: That he has made us suitable ministers of a New Covenant, not of letters, but of the Spirit.

Gospel. Lk. 4: 38 – 44

*It is necessary that I announce the good news to the other cities also;
for this I have been sent.*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

And he arose and left the synagogue, and entered Simon's house. Now Simon's mother-in-law was ill with a high fever, and they besought him for her. And he stood over her and rebuked the fever, and it left her; and immediately she rose and served them.

Now when the sun was setting, all those who had any that were sick with various diseases brought them to him; and he laid his hands on every one of them and healed them. And demons also came out of many, crying, "You are the Son of God!" But he rebuked them, and would not allow them to speak, because they knew that he was the Christ.

And when it was day he departed and went into a lonely place. And the people sought him and came to him, and would have kept him from leaving them; but he said to them, "I must preach the good news of the kingdom of God to the other cities also; for I was sent for this purpose." And he was preaching in the synagogues of Judea.

THURSDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading *Am. 4:1 – 13*

Against the woman of Samaria and the cult of Israel

A reading from the prophet Amos

"Hear this word, you cows of Bashan, who are in the mountain of Sama'ria, who oppress the poor, who crush the needy, who say to their husbands, 'Bring, so that we may drink!' The Lord GOD has sworn by his holiness that, behold, the days are coming upon you, when they shall take you away with hooks, even the last of you with fishhooks. And you shall go out through the breaches, every one straight before her; and you shall be cast forth into Harmon," says the LORD.

"Come to Bethel, and transgress; to Gilgal, and multiply transgression; bring your sacrifices every morning, your tithes every three days; offer a sacrifice of thanksgiving of that which is leavened, and proclaim freewill offerings, publish them; for so you love to do, O people of Israel!" says the Lord GOD. "I gave you cleanness of teeth in all your cities, and lack of bread in all your places, yet you did not return to me," says the LORD. "And I also withheld the rain from you when there were yet three months to the harvest; I would send rain upon one city, and send no rain upon another city; one field would be rained upon, and the field on which it did not rain withered; so two or three cities wandered to one city to drink water, and were not satisfied; yet you did not return to me," says the LORD.

"I smote you with blight and mildew; I laid waste your gardens and your vineyards; your fig trees and your olive trees the locust devoured; yet you did not return to me," says the LORD. "I sent among you a pestilence after the manner of Egypt; I slew your young men with the sword; I carried away your horses; and I made the stench of your camp go up into your nostrils; yet you did not return to me," says the LORD. "I overthrew some of you, as when God overthrew Sodom and Gomor'rah, and you were as a brand plucked out of the burning; yet you did not return to me," says the LORD. "Therefore thus I will do to you, O Israel; because I will do this to you: prepare to meet your God, O Israel!" For lo, he who forms the

mountains, and creates the wind, and declares to man what is his thought; who makes the morning darkness, and treads on the heights of the earth – the LORD, the God of hosts, is his name!

Responsorial *Ps. 49: 22-23; Mt. 1: 10*

R: Understand this, you who forget God, or I will tear you to pieces where no one can rescue you. * Whoever makes thanksgiving his sacrifice honours me, to the upright man I will show how God can save.

V: I am not pleased with you, says the Lord of hosts, I do not accept the offering of your hands!

R: Whoever makes thanksgiving his sacrifice honours me, to the upright man I will show how God can save.

Second Reading *C. 19: 1 – 3, 5 – 6, 8 – 12*

The way of light

A reading from the “Letter” attributed to Barnabas

The way of light, then, is as follows. If any one desires to travel to the appointed place, he must be zealous in his works. The knowledge, therefore, which is given to us for the purpose of walking in this way, is the following. You shall love Him that created you: you shall glorify Him that redeemed you from death. You shall be simple in heart, and rich in spirit. You shall not join yourself to those who walk in the way of death. You shall hate doing what is displeasing to God: You shall hate all hypocrisy. You shall not forsake the commandments of the Lord. You shall not exalt yourself, but shall be of a lowly mind. You shall not take glory to yourself. You shall not take evil counsel against your neighbour. You shall not allow over-boldness to enter into your soul. You shall not commit fornication: you shall not commit adultery: you shall not be a corrupter of youth. You shall not let the word of God issue from your lips with any kind of impurity. You shall not accept persons when you reprove any one for transgression. You shall be meek: You shall be peaceable. You shall tremble at the words that you hear. You shall not be mindful of evil against your brother. You shall not be of doubtful mind as to whether a thing shall be or not. You shall not take the name of the Lord in vain. You shall love your neighbour more than your own soul. You shall not slay the child by procuring abortion; nor, again, shall you destroy it after it is born. You shall not withdraw your hand

from your son, or from your daughter, but from their infancy you shall teach them the fear of the Lord. You shall not covet what is your neighbour's, nor shall you be avaricious. You shall not be joined in soul with the haughty, but you shall be reckoned with the righteous and lowly. Receive as good things the trials that come upon you. You shall not be of double mind or of double tongue, for a double tongue is a snare of death. You shall be subject to the Lord, and to [other] masters as the image of God, with modesty and fear. You shall not issue orders with bitterness to your maidservant or your manservant, who trust in the same [God], lest you should not reverence that God who is above both; for He came to call men not according to their outward appearance, but according as the Spirit had prepared them. You shall communicate in all things with your neighbour; you shall not call things your own; for if you are partakers in common of things which are incorruptible, how much more [should you be] of those things which are corruptible! You shall not be hasty with your tongue, for the mouth is a snare of death. As far as possible, you shall be pure in your soul. Do not be ready to stretch forth your hands to take, while you contract them to give. You shall love, as the apple of your eye, every one that speaks to you the word of the Lord. You shall remember the Day of Judgment, night and day. You shall seek out every day the faces of the saints, either by word examining them, and going to exhort them, and meditating how to save a soul by the Word, or by your hands you shall labour for the redemption of your sins. You shall not hesitate to give, or murmur when you give. "Give to every one that asks you," and you shall know who is the good Recompenser of the reward. You shall preserve what you have received [in charge], neither adding to it nor taking from it. To the last you shall hate the wicked [one]. You shall judge righteously. You shall not make a schism, but you shall pacify those that contend by bringing them together. You shall confess your sins. You shall not go to prayer with an evil conscience. This is the way of light.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Ps. 118: 101-102*

R: I keep my feet far away from all ways of evil; * I will keep your word, Lord.

V: I do not turn aside from your judgements, because you instruct me;

R: I will keep your word, Lord.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. 2 Tm. 2: 1 – 21

Exhortation to be constant in trials and in persecution.

A reading from the Second Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to Timothy.

You then, my son, be strong in the grace that is in Christ Jesus, and what you have heard from me before many witnesses entrust to faithful men who will be able to teach others also.

Share in suffering as a good soldier of Christ Jesus. No soldier on service gets entangled in civilian pursuits, since his aim is to satisfy the one who enlisted him. An athlete is not crowned unless he competes according to the rules. It is the hard-working farmer who ought to have the first share of the crops. Think over what I say, for the Lord will grant you understanding in everything.

Remember Jesus Christ, risen from the dead, descended from David, as preached in my gospel, the gospel for which I am suffering and wearing fetters like a criminal. But the word of God is not fettered. Therefore I endure everything for the sake of the elect, that they also may obtain salvation in Christ Jesus with its eternal glory.

The saying is sure: If we have died with him, we shall also live with him; if we endure, we shall also reign with him; if we deny him, he also will deny us; if we are faithless, he remains faithful -- for he cannot deny himself.

Remind them of this, and charge them before the Lord to avoid disputing about words, which does no good, but only ruins the hearers. Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a workman who has no need to be ashamed, rightly handling the word of truth.

Avoid such godless chatter, for it will lead people into more and more ungodliness, and their talk will eat its way like gangrene. Among them are Hymenae'us and Phile'tus, who have swerved from the truth by holding that the resurrection is past already. They are upsetting the faith of some.

But God's firm foundation stands, bearing this seal: "The Lord knows those who are his," and, "Let every one who names the name of the Lord

depart from iniquity."

In a great house there are not only vessels of gold and silver but also of wood and earthenware, and some for noble use, some for ignoble. If any one purifies himself from what is ignoble, then he will be a vessel for noble use, consecrated and useful to the master of the house, ready for any good work.

Responsorial. *2 Cor. 4: 10, 12; 2 Tm. 2: 10*

R: Always carrying in our bodies the death of Jesus, so that also the life of Jesus may be manifested in our bodies. * In a way that in us operates death, but in you life.

V: Therefore I bear everything for the elect, so that they also may reach salvation.

R: In a way that in us operates death, but in you life.

Second Reading. *Nm. 13 – 15*

Nothing is better than having peace in Christ.

A reading from the “Letter to the Ephesians” of St. Ignatius of Antioch, bishop and martyr.

Take heed, then, often to come together to give thanks to God, and show forth His praise. For when you come frequently together in the same place, the powers of Satan are destroyed, and his “fiery darts” urging to sin fall back ineffectual. For your concord and harmonious faith prove his destruction, and the torment of his assistants. Nothing is better than that peace which is according to Christ, by which all war, both of aerial and terrestrial spirits, is brought to an end. “For we wrestle not against blood and flesh, but against principalities and powers, and against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against spiritual wickedness in heavenly places.” (Ep. 6: 12). I do not want you therefore to hurt yourselves in some diabolical thought, as Paul also says, since you have in Christ the hope and love that are the beginning and the end of life. The beginning of life is faith, charity is its apex. The union of the two virtues, becoming unity, brings the man of God to perfection; it includes and makes all the other virtues that are practiced in the way of love perfect. He who professes the faith does not commit sin and he who possesses charity cannot hate. He in fact who said: “You will love the Lord your God with all your heart” also said: “Love your

neighbour as yourself” (Mt. 22: 37, 39). Thus those who make their profession of belonging to Christ are recognized not so much from what they say, but from their works. “Every tree in fact will be recognized by its fruit” (Lk. 6: 44). It is better to be a Christian without saying so, than to say it without being one, “because the kingdom of God does not consist in words, but in power” (1 Cor. 4: 20). “By believing from the heart you are made righteous, by confessing with your lips you are saved” (Rm. 10: 10).

It is a good thing to teach, if he who speaks practices what he teaches. He in fact “who observes and teaches them to men will be considered great in the kingdom of heaven” (Mt. 5: 19). Our God and Lord Jesus “Christ, the Son of the living God” (Mt. 16: 16) first “did” and then “taught” (Act. 1: 1), as Luke testifies, “the brother who is famous in all the churches for spreading the Gospel” (2 Cor. 8: 18).

Nothing is hidden from the Lord, even our secrets are in front of him.

Let us therefore do everything thinking that he dwells in us, in order that we may be his temple and he may be able to establish his dwelling in us.

Responsorial. *1 Jn. 4: 7; cfr. Sir. 25: 1, 2*

R: Dearly beloved, let us love one another, * because love comes from God.

V: The harmony among brothers and friendship among neighbours is pleasing to God and to men;

R: because love comes from God.

Gospel. *Lk. 5: 1 – 11*

They left everything and followed Him.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

While the people pressed upon him to hear the word of God, he was standing by the lake of Gennes'aret. And he saw two boats by the lake; but the fishermen had gone out of them and were washing their nets. Getting into one of the boats, which was Simon's, he asked him to put out a little from the land. And he sat down and taught the people from the boat.

And when he had ceased speaking, he said to Simon, "Put out into the deep and let down your nets for a catch." And Simon answered, "Master, we toiled all night and took nothing! But at your word I will let down the

nets." And when they had done this, they enclosed a great shoal of fish; and as their nets were breaking, they beckoned to their partners in the other boat to come and help them. And they came and filled both the boats, so that they began to sink. But when Simon Peter saw it, he fell down at Jesus' knees, saying, "Depart from me, for I am a sinful man, O Lord." For he was astonished, and all that were with him, at the catch of fish which they had taken; and so also were James and John, sons of Zeb'edee, who were partners with Simon. And Jesus said to Simon, "Do not be afraid; henceforth you will be catching men." And when they had brought their boats to land, they left everything and followed him.

FRIDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Am. 5: 1 – 17*

Lamentations and admonishments.

A reading from the book of Amos.

Hear this word which I take up over you in lamentation, O house of Israel: "Fallen, no more to rise, is the virgin Israel; forsaken on her land, with none to raise her up." For thus says the Lord GOD: "The city that went forth a thousand shall have a hundred left, and that which went forth a hundred shall have ten left to the house of Israel."

For thus says the LORD to the house of Israel: "Seek me and live; but do not seek Bethel, and do not enter into Gilgal or cross over to Beer-sheba; for Gilgal shall surely go into exile, and Bethel shall come to nought." Seek the LORD and live, lest he break out like fire in the house of Joseph, and it devour, with none to quench it for Bethel,

O you who turn justice to wormwood, and cast down righteousness to the earth! He who made the Pleiades and Orion, and turns deep darkness into the morning, and darkens the day into night, who calls for the waters of the sea, and pours them out upon the surface of the earth, the LORD is his name, who makes destruction flash forth against the strong, so that destruction comes upon the fortress.

They hate him who reproves in the gate, and they abhor him who speaks the truth. Therefore because you trample upon the poor and take from him exactions of wheat, you have built houses of hewn stone, but you shall not dwell in them; you have planted pleasant vineyards, but you shall not drink their wine. For I know how many are your transgressions, and how great are your sins -- you who afflict the righteous, who take a bribe, and turn aside the needy in the gate. Therefore he who is prudent will keep silent in such a time; for it is an evil time.

Seek good, and not evil, that you may live; and so the LORD, the God of hosts, will be with you, as you have said. Hate evil, and love good, and establish justice in the gate; it may be that the LORD, the God of hosts, will be gracious to the remnant of Joseph.

Therefore thus says the LORD, the God of hosts, the Lord: "In all the squares there shall be wailing; and in all the streets they shall say, 'Alas! Alas!' They shall call the farmers to mourning and to wailing those who are skilled in lamentation, and in all vineyards there shall be wailing, for I will pass through the midst of you," says the LORD.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Am. 5: 1, 12, 15, 14*

R: Listen to the word of the Lord: I know that your misdeeds are countless, that you are blackmailers, turning away the poor at the city gate. * Hate evil and love good; perhaps the Lord of hosts, will have pity.

V: Search for good and not evil, if you want to live, and thus the Lord, God of hosts, will be with you.

R: Hate evil and love good; perhaps the Lord of hosts, will have pity.

Second Reading. *Disc. 10: 13 – 14*

God the Father whips the Church so that it may grow more vigorous and fruitful.

A reading from the “Discourses” of the blessed Oglerio, abbot.

The universal Church is the vineyard of the Lord, consort and bride of Christ, of whom God the Father says to the Son: “Your bride like a fruitful vine in the intimacy of your house” (Ps. 127: 3). The vinedresser loves the vineyard which in its turn produces fruit, so at the time of the pruning he does not leave in it any part that is dry and withered. Then he digs around it up to the deepest roots, he uncovers the roots around the tree with a pointed hoe, and if it puts forth other small roots, he cuts it off with the pruning knife; and the more the vine loses in this way the parts that are less useful, or better still useless, the more it grows and produces blooming and abundant fruits.

In this way God strikes and beats those whom he loves: in fact he whips whoever he recognises as his son (cfr. Heb. 12: 6). To welcome correction here on earth is characteristic of those to whom it is given to enjoy eternity; but he who grumbles because of the correction does not draw near to him up there. On the contrary, if he does not welcome patiently and with love the punishment of God the Father, he loses the inheritance of the heavenly happiness. And if he has grumbled because of the correction

of the Lord, he may be certain that he will incur the punishment of the grumblers.

You therefore, dearest brothers, should not grumble if you run into the correction of our Lord, and do not lose heart when you are rebuked by him. Off course “any correction is painful at the time and far from pleasant; but later, on those on whom it has been used, it bears fruit in peace and justice” (Heb.12: 11). With the punishments of the Lord the ardour of the pleasures of the flesh become weak, while the vigour of the soul is renewed. The flesh loses that which it has in excess; and the spirit acquires the strength that it did not have. Thus through the punishments of the Lord, the strength increases and the vices are uprooted; the earthly things are despised and the heavenly things are loved.

We who await with impatience the eternal goods, when we are struck by some serious infirmity or by a strong temptation, or even by a loss of the temporal things, must draw strength from all these things, so that with the growing of the battle, we may not hesitate to believe that a more glorious victory awaits us. In fact in similar conditions we show with what ardour we bind ourselves to God, if we go to him not only in tranquillity and in prosperity, but also in the adverse and hard events.

We cannot reach to the eternal joys without losing the temporal goods; and therefore in the hope of the joy that does not pass, we must consider all the adverse conditions as not unfortunate.

The divine severity does not ever permit that our sins remain unpunished; but the anger of his judgement begins in the present with our correction, in order to find itself already satisfied in the moment of the condemnation of the reprobates. In fact the doctor is in our heart, and he cuts out the infection of sin in us: he takes out the poison of corruption with the knife of the tribulations. And this is what the Truth says: “Every branch in me which bears fruit”, my Father “prunes to make it bear even more fruit” (Jn. 15: 2): in fact the soul that finds itself in temptation, considers that which has driven it away from its preceding solidity in virtue, and worries anxiously about not losing all that which it had commenced to be. So grasp the sword of prayer, and the tears of compunction; and so weaken the temptations and you will triumph gloriously: not you, but the grace of Christ in you. And so it happens that the soul, which in prosperity lies down lazy and sterile, will rise up stronger and vigorous to bear fruits.

Responsorial. 2 Tm. 3: 11, 12; cfr. Jdt. 8: 26 (Vulg. 8: 23)

R: You know well of what persecutions I have suffered. Yet the Lord has liberated me from everything. * All those who want to live piously in Christ Jesus will be persecuted.

V: All those who are pleasing to God, will pass through many tribulations, and will remain faithful to him.

R: All those who want to live piously in Christ Jesus will be persecuted.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. 2 Tm. 2: 22 – 3:17

Dangerous times are drawing near.

A reading from the Second Letter to Timothy of St. Paul, apostle.

So shun youthful passions and aim at righteousness, faith, love, and peace, along with those who call upon the Lord from a pure heart. Have nothing to do with stupid, senseless controversies; you know that they breed quarrels. And the Lord's servant must not be quarrelsome but kindly to every one, an apt teacher, forbearing, correcting his opponents with gentleness. God may perhaps grant that they will repent and come to know the truth, and they may escape from the snare of the devil, after being captured by him to do his will.

But understand this, that in the last days there will come times of stress. For men will be lovers of self, lovers of money, proud, arrogant, abusive, disobedient to their parents, ungrateful, unholy, inhuman, implacable, slanderers, profligates, fierce, haters of good, treacherous, reckless, swollen with conceit, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God, holding the form of religion but denying the power of it. Avoid such people.

For among them are those who make their way into households and capture weak women, burdened with sins and swayed by various impulses, who will listen to anybody and can never arrive at a knowledge of the truth.

As Jannes and Jambres opposed Moses, so these men also oppose the truth, men of corrupt mind and counterfeit faith; but they will not get very far, for their folly will be plain to all, as was that of those two men.

Now you have observed my teaching, my conduct, my aim in life, my faith, my patience, my love, my steadfastness, my persecutions, my

sufferings, what befell me at Antioch, at Ico'nium, and at Lystra, what persecutions I endured; yet from them all the Lord rescued me. Indeed all who desire to live a godly life in Christ Jesus will be persecuted, while evil men and impostors will go on from bad to worse, deceivers and deceived.

But as for you, continue in what you have learned and have firmly believed, knowing from whom you learned it and how from childhood you have been acquainted with the sacred writings which are able to instruct you for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus. All scripture is inspired by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work.

Responsorial. *2 Tm. 2: 24, 25; Ez. 33: 11*

R: A servant of the Lord must be meek with everyone. He has to be gentle when he corrects people who dispute what he says, * God will grant them conversion, so that they may recognise the truth.

V: God does not take pleasure in the death of the wicked, but that the wicked desists from his conduct and lives.

R: God will grant them conversion, so that they may recognise the truth.

Second Reading. *Nm. 16 – 19*

The cross is salvation and eternal life for us.

A reading from the “Letter to the Ephesians” of St, Ignatius of Antioch, bishop and martyr.

Do not err, my brethren. Those that corrupt families shall not inherit the kingdom of God. And if those that corrupt mere human families are condemned to death, how much more shall those suffer everlasting punishment who endeavour to corrupt the Church of Christ, for which the Lord Jesus, the only-begotten Son of God, endured the cross, and submitted to death! Whosoever, “being waxen fat,” and “become gross,” sets at nought His doctrine, shall go into hell. In like manner, every one that has received from God the power of discerning, and yet follows an unskilful shepherd, and receives a false opinion for the truth, shall be punished. “What communion has light with darkness? Or Christ with Belial? Or what portion has he that believes with an infidel? Or the temple of God with idols?” And in like manner say I, what communion has truth with

falsehood? Or righteousness with unrighteousness? Or true doctrine with that which is false? For this end did the Lord suffer the ointment to be poured upon His head, that His Church might breathe forth immortality. For says [the Scripture], “Your name is as ointment poured forth; therefore have the virgins loved You; they have drawn after You; at the odour of Your ointments we will run after You.” Let no one be anointed with the bad odour of the doctrine of [the prince of] this world; let not the holy Church of God be led captive by his subtlety, as was the first woman. Why do we not, as gifted with reason, act wisely? When we had received from Christ, and had grafted in us the faculty of judging concerning God, why do we fall headlong into ignorance? And why, through a careless neglect of acknowledging the gift that we have received, do we foolishly perish?

The cross of Christ is indeed a stumbling block to those that do not believe, but to the believing it is salvation and life eternal. “Where is the wise man? Where the disputer?” Where is the boasting of those who are called mighty? For the Son of God, who was begotten before time began, and established all things according to the will of the Father, He was conceived in the womb of Mary, according to the appointment of God, of the seed of David, and by the Holy Spirit. For says [the Scripture], “Behold, a virgin shall be with child, and shall bring forth a son, and He shall be called Immanuel.” He was born and was baptized by John, that He might ratify the institution committed to that prophet. Now the virginity of Mary was hidden from the prince of this world, as was also her offspring, and the death of the Lord; three mysteries of renown, which were wrought in silence, but have been revealed to us. A star shone forth in heavens above all that were before it, and its light was inexpressible, while its novelty struck men with astonishment. And all the rest of the stars, with the sun and moon, formed a chorus to this star. It far exceeded them all in brightness, and agitation was felt as to whence this new spectacle [proceeded]. Hence worldly wisdom became folly; conjuration was seen to be mere trifling; and magic became utterly ridiculous. Every law of wickedness vanished away; the darkness of ignorance was dispersed; and tyrannical authority was destroyed, God being manifested as a man, and man displaying power as God. But neither was the former a mere imagination, nor did the second imply a bare humanity; but the one was absolutely true, and the other an economical arrangement. Now that received a beginning that was perfected by God.

Henceforth all things were in a state of tumult, because He meditated the abolition of death.

Responsorial. *Jn. 13: 16, 17, 15*

R: A servant is not greater than his master. * Knowing these things, you will be blessed if you put them into practice.

V: I have given you in fact an example, because as I have done you too may do.

R: Knowing these things, you will be blessed if you put them into practice.

Gospel. *Lk. 5: 33 – 39*

When the bridegroom will be taken away from them, then they will fast.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

And they said to him, “The disciples of John fast often and offer prayers, and so do the disciples of the Pharisees, but yours eat and drink.”

And Jesus said to them, "Can you make wedding guests fast while the bridegroom is with them? The days will come, when the bridegroom is taken away from them, and then they will fast in those days.”

He told them a parable also: “No one tears a piece from a new garment and puts it upon an old garment; if he does, he will tear the new, and the piece from the new will not match the old.

And no one puts new wine into old wineskins; if he does, the new wine will burst the skins and it will be spilled, and the skins will be destroyed. But new wine must be put into fresh wineskins. And no one after drinking old wine desires new; for he says, ‘The old is good.’”

SATURDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading Amos 5:18 – 6:15

The day of the Lord. Against the cult and false security

Woe to you who desire the day of the LORD! Why would you have the day of the LORD? It is darkness, and not light; as if a man fled from a lion, and a bear met him; or went into the house and leaned with his hand against the wall, and a serpent bit him. Is not the day of the LORD darkness, and not light, and gloom with no brightness in it?

“I hate, I despise your feasts, and I take no delight in your solemn assemblies. Even though you offer me your burnt offerings and cereal offerings, I will not accept them, and the peace offerings of your fatted beasts I will not look upon...the noise of your songs; to the melody of your harps I will not listen. But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream. Did you bring to me sacrifices and offerings the forty years in the wilderness, O house of Israel? You shall take up Sakkuth your king, and Kaiwan your star-god, your images, which you made for yourselves; therefore I will take you into exile beyond Damascus” says the LORD, whose name is the God of hosts.

“Woe to those who are at ease in Zion, and to those who feel secure on the mountain of Sama'ria, the notable men of the first of the nations, to whom the house of Israel come! Pass over to Calneh, and see; then go to Hamath the great; and then go down to Gath of the Philistines. Are they better than these kingdoms? Or is their territory greater than your territory, O you who put far away the evil day, and bring near the seat of violence?

“Woe to those who lie upon beds of ivory, and stretch themselves upon their couches, and eat lambs from the flock, and calves from the midst of the stall; who sing idle songs to the sound of the harp, and like David invent for themselves instruments of music; who drink wine in bowls, and anoint themselves with the finest oils, but are not grieved over the ruin of Joseph! Therefore they shall now be the first of those to go into exile and the revelry of those who stretch themselves shall pass away.”

The Lord GOD has sworn by himself (says the LORD, the God of hosts): “I abhor the pride of Jacob, and hate his strongholds; and I will

deliver up the city and all that is in it." And if ten men remain in one house, they shall die. And when a man's kinsman, he who burns him, shall take him up to bring the bones out of the house, and shall say to him who is in the innermost parts of the house, "Is there still any one with you?" he shall say, "No"; and he shall say, "Hush! We must not mention the name of the LORD." For behold, the LORD commands, and the great house shall be smitten into fragments, and the little house into bits. Do horses run upon rocks? Does one plough the sea with oxen? But you have turned justice into poison and the fruit of righteousness into wormwood -- you who rejoice in Lo-debar, who say, "Have we not by our own strength taken Karnaim for ourselves?"

"For behold, I will raise up against you a nation, O house of Israel," says the LORD, the God of hosts; "and they shall oppress you from the entrance of Hamath to the Brook of the Arabah."

Responsorial *Amos 5:18, 21, 6, 8, 20*

R: Woe to those who desire the day of the Lord! I detest and repulse your feasts and am not pleased with your gatherings. * Search for the Lord, he who turns darkness into the first light of the morning.

V: Is not the day of the Lord darkness and not light, and gloom with no brightness in it?

R: Search for the Lord, he who turns darkness into the first light of the morning.

Second Reading *Book 17:4 – 6*

I want love more than sacrifice

A reading from the treatise “Against the heresies” of St. Irenaeus, bishop

God did not demand sacrifices and holocausts from the Hebrews, but faith, obedience and justice for their salvation. Through the prophet Hosea he displayed his will to them in these words: “I want love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God more than holocausts” (Hos 6:6). But our Lord also gave them the same teaching saying: “If you had understood what signifies: I want love and not sacrifice, you would not have condemned the individual without fault (cf. Mt 12:7). Thus he gave witness to the truth of the prophets, while he accused his interlocutors, as fools and guilty.

Similarly Christ recommended his disciples to offer the first fruits of his creatures to God, not because he had need of them, but so that they themselves would not be ungrateful and without fruit. For this he took bread, which comes from the created world, and gave thanks saying: “This is my body”. In the same way he took the chalice of wine, which also comes from the cosmic reality to which we ourselves belong, he called it his blood and said that it was a new oblation of the New Covenant (cf. Mt 26:28).

The Church has received this offering from the hands of the apostles and offers it to that God who gives us the nourishment, as the first fruits of the gifts of the New Covenant. This oblation was pre-announced by Malachi, one of the twelve prophets, when he said: “I am not pleased with you, says Yahweh Sabaoth, from your hands I find no offerings acceptable. But from the farthest east to the farthest west my name is honoured among the nations and everywhere a sacrifice of incense is offered to my name, and a pure offering too, since my name is honoured among the nations, says Yahweh Sabaoth” (Mal 1:10-11). With these words he indicated clearly that the first people would cease to make offerings to God; while in every place a new sacrifice would have been immolated to God, but this one truly pure, and thus his name would be glorified among the nations. And what other name is there which can be glorified among the nations if not that of our Lord, through whom the Father is glorified and through whom man receives glory? But it is exactly because this is the name of his own Son and comes from him (cf. 1:21; Lk 1:31) that he calls him his.

If a king was himself to paint the image of his son, justly he would say that the portrait was his, for the double reason that it is of his son and that he himself had done it. This is what happens with the name of Jesus Christ, who receives glory in the entire world in the Church. The Father has declared this name his, both because it is the name of his Son, and because he has incised it himself, giving him for the salvation of men (cf. Act 4:12).

Therefore the name of the Son belonging to the Father and to the Church makes its offering to the Almighty God in every place through Jesus Christ. Keeping in mind this double fact, the prophet could justly say: “And in every place, incense and a pure oblation is offered to my name” (Mal 1:11).

This incense, according to Saint John, is the figure of the “prayers of the saints” (Rev 5:8).

Responsorial *Cf. Lk 22:19, 20; Pr 9:6*

R: This is my body, given for you; this is my blood of the new covenant, poured out for you, says the Lord. * Do this in memory of me.

V: Come, eat my bread, drink the wine that I have prepared for you.

R: Do this in memory of me.

CYCLE 2

First Reading *2 Tim 4:1 – 22*

Final exhortation of Paul

I charge you in the presence of God and of Christ Jesus who is to judge the living and the dead, and by his appearing and his kingdom: preach the word, be urgent in season and out of season, convince, rebuke, and exhort, be unfailing in patience and in teaching. For the time is coming when people will not endure sound teaching, but having itching ears they will accumulate for themselves teachers to suit their own likings, and will turn away from listening to the truth and wander into myths. As for you, always be steady, endure suffering, do the work of an evangelist, fulfil your ministry.

For I am already on the point of being sacrificed; the time of my departure has come. I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith. Henceforth there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, will award to me on that Day, and not only to me but also to all who have loved his appearing.

Do your best to come to me soon. For Demas, in love with this present world, has deserted me and gone to Thessalonica; Crescens has gone to Galatia, Titus to Dalmatia. Luke alone is with me. Get Mark and bring him with you; for he is very useful in serving me. Tychicus I have sent to Ephesus. When you come, bring the cloak that I left with Carpus at Troas, also the books, and above all the parchments. Alexander the coppersmith did me great harm; the Lord will requite him for his deeds. Beware of him yourself, for he strongly opposed our message.

At my first defence no one took my part; all deserted me. May it not be charged against them!

But the Lord stood by me and gave me strength to proclaim the message fully, that all the Gentiles might hear it. So I was rescued from the lion's mouth. The Lord will rescue me from every evil and save me for his heavenly kingdom. To him be the glory forever and ever. Amen. Greet Prisca and Aq'uila, and the household of Onesiph'orus. Eras'tus remained at Corinth; Troph'imus I left ill at Mile'tus. Do your best to come before winter. Eubu'lus sends greetings to you, as do Pudens and Linus and Claudia and all the brethren. The Lord be with your spirit. Grace be with you.

Responsorial 2 Tim 4:2, 5; Phil 1:18

R: Announce the word and, welcome or unwelcome, insist on every occasion, refute falsehood, correct error, call to obedience, but do all with patience and with the intention of teaching * know how to bear sufferings, fulfil the work of the announcer of the gospel.

V: Whether from dishonest motives or in sincerity, Christ is announced,

R: know how to bear sufferings, fulfil the work of the announcer of the gospel.

Second Reading Num 20 – 21

I am ready to give my life for you

A reading from the “Letter to the Ephesians” of St. Ignatius of Antioch, bishop and martyr

If Jesus Christ shall graciously permit me through your prayers, and if it be His will, I shall, in a second little work which I will write to you, make further manifest to you [the nature of] the dispensation of which I have begun [to treat], with respect to the new man, Jesus Christ, in His faith and in His love, in His suffering and in His resurrection. Especially [will I do this] if the Lord make known to me that you come together man by man in communion through grace, individually, in one faith, and in Jesus Christ, who was of the seed of David according to the flesh, being both the Son of man and the Son of God, so that you obey the bishop and the presbytery with an undivided mind, breaking one and the same bread, which is the medicine of immortality, and the antidote to prevent us from dying, but [which causes] that we should live for ever in Jesus Christ. Stand fast, brethren, in the faith of Jesus Christ, and in His love, in His passion, and in

His resurrection. Do you all come together in communion and individually, through grace, in one faith of God the Father, and of Jesus Christ His only-begotten Son, and “the first-born of every creature,” but of the seed of David according to the flesh, being under the guidance of the Comforter, in obedience to the bishop and the presbytery with an undivided mind, breaking one and the same bread, which is the medicine of immortality, and the antidote which prevents us from dying, but a cleansing remedy driving away evil, [which causes] that we should live in God through Jesus Christ.

My soul be for yours and theirs whom, for the honour of God, you have sent to Smyrna; whence also I write to you, giving thanks to the Lord, and loving Polycarp even as I do you. Remember me, as Jesus Christ also remembers you, who is blessed for evermore. Pray for the Church of Antioch which is in Syria, whence I am led bound to Rome, being the last of the faithful that are there, who yet have been thought worthy to carry these chains to the honour of God. Fare well in God the Father, and the Lord Jesus Christ, our common hope, and in the Holy Spirit.

Responsorial *2 Cor 12: 14- 15; Phil 2: 17*

R: I do not want your goods, but you. In fact children are not expected to save up for their parents, but parents for children. I am perfectly willing to spend what I have, * on the contrary I will be expended, in the interests of your souls.

V: And even if my blood has to be poured out in libation as part of your own sacrifice and offering- which is your faith- I shall still be happy;

R: on the contrary I will be expended, in the interests of your souls.

Gospel: *Lk 6:1 – 5*

Why do you do what is not permitted on the Sabbath.

On a Sabbath, while he was going through the grain fields, his disciples plucked and ate some heads of grain, rubbing them in their hands.

But some of the Pharisees said, "Why are you doing what is not lawful to do on the Sabbath?" And Jesus answered, "Have you not read what David

did when he was hungry, he and those who were with him: how he entered the house of God, and took and ate the bread of the Presence, which it is not lawful for any but the priests to eat, and also gave it to those with him?" And he said to them, "The Son of man is Lord of the Sabbath."